

Upper Structures: voicings for V7 chords



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**Your challenge: Choose your favorite upper structures.
Build them from all 12 notes. Then apply them to Jazz songs.**

Difficulty level = Medium

Upper Structures are a great way to voice V7 chords in two hands. Simply play the chord's 1 3 7 in your left hand. Then choose from the following triads to play above in your right hand. Each triad adds a different set of extensions to the V7 chord.

First, here are all the upper structures can be played over C7:

PIANO

$C7(\sharp 11)$	$C7(\sharp 9)$	$C7(\sharp \frac{11}{9})$	$C7(\sharp \frac{11}{9})$
C7 + D maj	C7 + Eb maj	C7 + Eb min	C7 + F# maj

$C7(\sharp \frac{11}{9})$	$C7(\flat \frac{13}{9})$	$C7(\flat 9)$
C7 + F# min	C7 + Ab maj	C7 + A maj

To play an upper structure, you must first find the correct scale degree to build the triad (e.g. 2nd, min 3rd, maj 6th, etc). Count this carefully from the root of the chord. Then build a major or minor chord from that note.

Personally, I only use three upper structures in my playing:

$C7(\sharp 11)$	$C7(\flat \frac{13}{9})$	$C7(\flat 9)$
C7 + D maj (most used)	C7 + Ab maj	C7 + A maj (most used)

There's lots of ways you can voice an upper structure:

You can invert your right hand's triad (1 3 5, 3 5 1, 5 1 3).

Or you can cut down a triad, or double it in an octave.

Here are some examples:

C7 + D maj $C7(\sharp 11)$ $C7(\sharp 11)$ $C7(\sharp 11)$ $C7(\sharp 11)$ $C7(\sharp 11)$

root pos. 1st inv. 2nd inv. +octave cut off

You can even play 1 7 3 if you can stretch it

C7 + Ab maj $C7(\flat 13)$ $C7(\flat 13)$ $C7(\flat 13)$ $C7(\flat 13)$

cut off 1st inv. 2nd inv. +octave

C7 + A maj $C7(\flat 9)$ $C7(\flat 9)$ $C7(\flat 9)$

1st inv. 2nd inv. +octave

"When should I play an upper structure?"

When there's a V7 chord held for 2-4 beats (certainly 4 beats).

Upper structures have lots of rich harmony, so they're supposed to be sustained for several seconds (anything shorter and your ear can't take it all in).

'Melody Matching':

Your goal is to get the top note of your chord voicing to be the melody note.

This will always be possible, using any of the techniques above:

(invert the triad, cut off a note, or double in octaves).

Practice 1. Choose an upper structure to learn. Build it from all 12 notes (1 week).

Practice 2. Play through songs in your real book. Apply upper structures to every suitable V7 chords. (Misty, Tenderly, Taxi Driver, Stompin' At The Savoy).